ground. He and his team reached the chief minister's residence at 4 p.m. as scheduled. Ratan once again made a departure from the company's policy of the MD and chairman keeping out of wage settlement negotiations. It was a risky move as it might have created a precedent and expectation among workers of the chairman attending labour meetings.

TKS tried to make things as difficult as possible for Ratan. In a bid to exert psychological pressure on the management, Nair and his team kept Ratan and his colleagues waiting for an hour and a half. The management team was, however, unfazed. The meeting ended in failure as Nair refused to budge from his earlier stance. Ratan too refused to relent. It was a test of nerves, and the new chairman of TELCO was not one to blink first.

Ending the Unrest

The media had begun to report that the situation was getting worse. The apparently deteriorating condition of the thousands of striking workers was gaining public attention. Some had started complaining of nausea and blurred vision and hundreds were moved to the Sassoon General Hospital. A marriage hall in front of the fort was converted to a makeshift ward and doctors and nurses were reportedly 'administering saline to emergency cases'. Such news coverage threatened to portray the management in poor light.

Ratan realized that 'there [had] been considerable public opinion created through various press reports, and TELCO [had] erred in not making its position publicly known'. Marking a beginning, he went on a peremptory public opinion-building exercise. He held a press conference on 28 September and followed it with a press release.

Concurrently, Ratan appealed to the government at the Centre to intervene and impressed upon them the unreasonableness of the position taken by the TKS. TELCO was the 'highest' paymaster in the region and the demands of the trade union were blatantly unjustifiable and high-handed, he said. He persuaded Rajinder Kumar Dhawan, who had been the close confidant of and personal assistant to former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi and officer on special duty (OSD) to Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, to communicate with Pawar and find a solution to end the prolonged strike. In addition, it was reported that Rajiv Gandhi would be visiting Khopoli, some 61 km from Pune.